



### Calling on the dead

Curses represented the darker side of Greek magic, surpassed only by necromancy, the art of speaking with, or even raising, the dead, which took place at sites such as the Necromanteion in Epirus. Some curses were written on *lamellae* (thin lead sheets), which were then rolled up and deposited in wells or buried with corpses, who would convey the invoker's desires to underworld powers such as the Furies and the *Praxidikai*—demonic spirits

of vengeance. Hundreds of these curse tablets have been found across the Greek world, and the practice later spread into the Roman Empire, as far as Britain. Grievances included calls for justice against thieves, unfaithful spouses, or business competitors. While the Greeks might thank the gods, offering clay models of heads, legs, or wombs for the success of magic healing rituals, they were not above calling on those same powers to inflict deadly damage on their enemies.

### ▲ Curse tablet

The spell on this 5th-century BCE tablet from Sicily calls for the writer's rivals in a legal case to be rendered incapable of pleading their side of the argument in court.